SUNY Old Westbury 2026-2027 Undergraduate Catalog

Course Descriptions

Contract All Courses |

Sociology

SY 1500 - Introductory Sociology

Credits: 4

Introduces basic concepts and perspectives in sociology. Such major social institutions as the family, education, politics, law, media, and religion are examined, together with such social processes as socialization, social change, social control, and social stratification. In addition, the course surveys some of the research methods and social theories in sociology. Designed as a general interest and Liberal Education Curriculum course. Required for sociology and criminology majors.

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 2222 - Care & Care Work

Credits: 4

This course will examine the subject of care work with a focus on the ways in which social processes and institutions shape individual experiences (and vice versa). Drawing on historical and contemporary illustrations of the paid and unpaid work of caring, we will use a sociological lens to consider questions such as: What does it mean to care? Who receives care? Who does the work of caring? Where, and under what circumstances, does this work happen? At what costs does care work happen, and how is that work valued and supported? How are paid and unpaid care work divided along lines of gender, race, class, and nationality? Throughout the course, students will engage with these questions by applying sociological concepts to popular debates, historical events, and original data.

Prerequisites

EC1

Note:

I updated course title here to reflect change since last catalog - cross-listed course name matches.

SY 2222 - Sociology of Caring

Credits: 4

This course will examine the subject of care work with a focus on the ways in which social processes and institutions shape individual experiences (and vice versa). Drawing on historical and contemporary illustrations of the paid and unpaid work of caring, we will use a sociological lens to consider questions such as: What does it mean to care? Who receives care? Who does the work of caring? Where, and under what circumstances, does this work happen? At what costs does care work happen, and how is that work valued and supported? How are paid and unpaid care work divided along lines of gender, race, class, and nationality? Throughout the course, students will engage with these questions by applying sociological concepts to popular debates, historical events, and original data.

Prerequisites

EC1

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 2400 - Sociology Through the Arts

Credits: 4

This course considers the dynamic tension that exists between artists and the many roles that the arts have had in society by examining the literary arts, visual arts, and the performing arts (in sum: painting and drawing; music, dance and theater; literature and poetry; and, photography and film/video). In the process of exploring the arts, we will consider the social factors that enable artistic expression to come to fruition as artistic genres are constructed. We will also analyze how the arts may serve as boundary-making social activity (i.e., by contesting an indicator of taste or style), or as boundary-breaking cultural endeavors (i.e., by contesting social rules and norms). Students will learn to critically assess the function of the arts at both the local, "street" level, as well as art circulating in the global marketplace. Students will also be encouraged to produce their own artistic contribution in response to the course material, thereby experiencing the connection between art and society as a distinctive component of our common humanity.

Prerequisites

EC1

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 2550 - Social Problems

Credits: 4

Examines the historical and contemporary roots of critical social problems such as poverty, unemployment, ecological despoliation, delinquency, population growth, etc. Also of concern are the social policies directed toward these problems and an examination of their present and future consequences.

Prerequisites

ECI

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 2600 - Social Deviance

Credits: 4

Examines the patterns of deviant behavior in American society. Concentrates on the social construction of deviance: how various deviant labels are defined and applied (e.g. crime and mental illness) and the social consequences for those labeled. Students will also study the uses of moral, legal and medical models as fundamental ways of understanding both deviant behavior and the societal response to deviants.

Prerequisites

ECI

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 2800 - Race, Class, Gender & Sexuality

Credits: 4

In this course students will examine the multiple and intersecting ways in which race, class, gender, and sexuality shape and are shaped by institutions, interaction, and individual experience. The course will explore the social construction of these concepts, the meanings and values attached to them, the ways in which they are embedded in sites of inequality, and efforts to transform them.

Prerequisites

ECI

SY 2999 - Science, Religion and Knowledge

Credits: 4

This course is designed to serve two separate but interrelated purposes: descriptive and analytical. The ideas, concepts and skills developed in this course will form the basis for an understanding of the sociology of knowledge. In this course we will explore the relationships among science, belief systems (e.g., religion), social structure, historical development and power. We will take as our subject matter the history and sociology of knowledge. Using historical trends and a variety of illustrative "case studies" we will explore the social and cultural origins, effects, and meaning of "science" as one way of our experiences in the universe as we know it. We will explore different theoretical models and ways of thinking of these issues as a way to understand what science is, how it is related to American (and more generally, Western) society, and what some of its effects have been. We will pay special attention to the role of power, authority and conflict.

Prerequisites

ECI

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3160 - Sociology of Culture

Credits: 4

This course engages students in the social science theories and research studies in diverse culture fields of contemporary and globalized society. Material and non-material aspects of cultural analysis are explored in such fields as language,

technology, arts, and media through their relationship to the culture production/consumption processes. Debates about culture, policy, and culture change are analyzed in the course, and include the new research on visual culture and civic culture.

Prerequisites

ECll

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3280 - Social Inequality

Credits: 4

This course analyzes the basic dimensions of structured social inequality, the unequal distribution of wealth, power, goods and services by class, race and gender. It studies different aspects of the impact of social inequality: for example, on environmental issues; social mobility; beliefs about the justice of inequality; social movements; crime, poverty and social policy.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3630 - Political Sociology

Credits: 4

Examines the social structures and processes related to participation in the political life of society. Explores the problems the political order poses for different social classes and how institutions of power and authority are maintained in efforts to foster control and legitimacy.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3700 - Family and Society

Credits: 4

Through historical and comparative analysis, studies the connection between courtship and marriage patterns and different economic systems. Students examine the emergence of the modern family system, changing patterns of mate selection and courtship and the relationship between general assumptions about sex roles and role allocation in marriage itself. Comparisons are drawn across cultures and across class, race and ethnic groups in American society.

Prerequisites

ECII

SY 3750 - Medical Sociology

Credits: 4

Explores the social forces defining and influencing health and illness. The organization and distribution of medical science and professionals are analyzed from a sociological perspective, with an emphasis on care for the poor, minorities, women, the disabled, and the aged. Alternatives to the present system of medical care in the U.S. are discussed, particularly in the context of health policy and medical care in other countries.

Prerequisites

EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3800 - Race and Ethnicity

Credits: 4

Emphasizes the history, social structure and culture of racial national, ethnic and religious minorities. Includes such minority majority processes as interracial and intercultural conflict, domination and adaptation, accommodation and

assimilation. Causes and consequences of prejudice, racism and discrimination and some ways of reducing intergroup tensions are included as are alternative models for pluralistic societies such as “melting pots” or “mosaics.”

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3830 - Gender and Society

Credits: 4

Sociologists view gender as a socially constructed phenomenon - a characteristic of individuals, interactions, and institutions that is shaped by social context. This course examines the ways in which gender is constructed and maintained, and the ways in which these processes uphold social inequalities. Attention will be paid to the ways in which these processes are shaped by social dimensions such as race, ethnicity, social class, and sexuality as well as efforts to mitigate inequalities and to challenge normative gender constructs.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

Note:

Adding cross-list WS 3299 - all pre-reqs, GenEds, course info should be the same.

SY 3900 - Social Movements

Credits: 4

Provides an overview of the contemporary sociological models used to analyze the dynamics of protest among disenfranchised constituencies in the U.S. Cases are drawn largely from the history of African American protest movements of the 19th and 20th century in which activists have attempted to reconcile tensions between demand for civil rights and the more radical vision of nationhood. Government and counter-movement responses to protest are also examined.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 3910 - Sociology of Work

Credits: 4

This course will introduce students to the sociology of work and industry. We will cover the history of work organization from ancient to modern times, but with particular emphasis on contemporary, 'post-industrial' capitalism. Topics to be discussed include industrial organization, bureaucracy, gender, race and ethnicity in the workplace, work and family balance, the development of the trade union movement and collective bargaining. All of these more specific areas of inquiry will be framed against the backdrop of an evolving world economy and the role of the U.S. and U.S. workers in it. The goal of the course is to provide students with a broad understanding of both the history and the myriad theoretical approaches to work, as well as research strategies for their empirical investigation.

Prerequisites

ECII

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4260 - Social Work: Theory and Practice

Credits: 4

Examines social work practice as a planned change process occurring within systems, i.e., one-to-one relationships, families, community groups. Provides a general overview of social work practice within the context of social welfare. Particular attention is paid to the structure and function of social welfare as an institution and to the development of concepts and techniques applicable to a wide variety of social work settings and situations. Addresses such issues as the types of opportunities in the field, necessary skills and the underlying value system.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

or PY 2010

, EMS

When Offered:

Every year.

SY 4270 - Internship in Social Work, Sociology and Criminology

Credits: 4

The internship program is designed for students who wish to develop practical skills and gain work experience in the fields of Social Work, Sociology and Criminology, integrating theory with professional experience. The students will have an opportunity to explore the professional world and to acquire training in their chosen area of specialization. The student in conjunction with the instructor will select a field internship and perform 90 hours of field work. Students meet regularly to discuss their experiences and progress. They will compile a portfolio of the work done on the internship and write a detailed report describing the agency and summarizing their work. The student will use psychological, sociological and criminological theories and research to explain complex social processes experienced during the field.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS; Junior standing

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4400 - Social Psychology

Credits: 4

Introduces the social psychological theories of sociologists and anthropologists to show how culture and society shape and influence behavior. Focus is on theories of socialization, such as symbolic interaction, behaviorism, small group theories, perception, social exchange, etc. Consideration is given to cross-cultural examples.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4500 - Global Sociology

Credits: 4

The major aims of the course are to broaden student knowledge and perspectives of diverse cultures and the global society by using historical, anthropological, and sociological theories and methods. The course will review such social processes as socio-cultural evolution, development and revolution. We will do comparative analyses, and debate global issues and policies. The global issues include the environment, population, resources, and technology; global stratification, human rights, and peace and war in contemporary society.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 4520 - Research Methods I

Credits: 4

Introduces students to the concepts and principles of sociological research, including how to: interpret and construct academic research articles, conduct an analytic literature review, design and test research hypotheses, use appropriate sampling methods and apply ethical principles. Students will gain experience in qualitative data collection methods and analysis (e.g., intensive interviews, content analysis, ethnography, group interviews, question construction, historical/comparative studies) for sociology and criminology topics, and develop a research plan.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

; EMS

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 4530 - Sociological Theory I

Credits: 4

Introduces the central concepts and theoretical frameworks of the founding figures of classical sociological theory: Marx, Durkheim, and Weber. By reading primary work by each theorist as well as secondary sources, students will learn the content of the theories, the theorists' underlying assumptions, and the empirical bases of their analyses of society.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 4540 - Sociological Theory II

Credits: 4

Introduces modern developments in sociological theory. Students will read both primary and secondary contemporary theoretical writings, studying how modern theory builds on and diverges from classical theories. Major fields of contemporary theory that may be covered include: functionalism, conflict theory, neo-Marxist theories, psychoanalytic theory, feminist theory and critical race theory. The emphasis is on understanding how each theorist approaches his/her own realm of inquiry as well as the actual idea systems created.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, SY 4530

with a grade of "C-" or better; EMS

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 4570 - Research Methods II

Credits: 4

Trains students to collect and analyze quantitative sociological data. Topics include appropriate sampling methods, survey research, probability, tests of significance and descriptive and inferential statistics. Students are introduced to statistical logic and concepts and conduct bivariate and multivariate analyses using examples from sociology and criminology.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, SY 4520

; EMS, Math Proficiency

When Offered:

Every semester.

SY 4600 - Social Programs, Planning and Policy

Credits: 4

Analyzes formation of social policy, its effectiveness as applied to specific social institutions and programs, as well as the impact of these programs on their targeted population. Broader issues of social policy within the context of political economic systems and ideologies, as well as the general structure of the American "Welfare State," will be discussed, using cross-cultural comparisons.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4651 - Sociology of Communications and Media

Credits: 4

Students will study the social science perspective in the large field of communications media, including the theories and applied research on the social, political, and economic contexts of media. Learning objectives also include looking critically at media production, producers, products, and social effects in a dynamic relationship called mediatization. The multi-mediated environment poses a number of debates about the representation of age, class, gender, race/ethnicity, and other status categories. Students study contemporary research methods such as content analysis, which supports the "media literacy" movement in global society.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

SY 4810 - Law and Justice

Credits: 4

This course focuses on the sociological understanding of how ideas of law and justice relate to issues of power, consensus, conflict and change in society. It examines the use of law as a tool in responding to different cultural groups in American society and examines the process and significance of judicial law-making under the U.S. Constitution, illustrated by case examples regarding first amendment guarantees of religious freedom and political dissent, and civil rights issues of race, nationality, gender, sexuality and disability.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4830 - Gender and Society

Credits: 4

Sociologists view gender as a socially constructed phenomenon - a characteristic of individuals, interactions, and institutions that is shaped by social context. This course examines the ways in which gender is constructed and maintained, and the ways in which these processes uphold social inequalities. Attention will be paid to the ways in

which these processes are shaped by social dimensions such as race, ethnicity, social class, and sexuality as well as efforts to mitigate inequalities and to challenge normative gender constructs.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

SY 4850 - Urban and Suburban Sociology

Credits: 4

Introduces a variety of sociological perspectives on urbanization and community formation. The history of urban development is traced in terms of major social changes contributing to and resulting from the rise of cities. The expansion of cities into metropolitan regions is examined in relation to social processes in urban areas. Select problems that have arisen out of the American urban experience are considered together with such efforts to ameliorate them as urban renewal efforts and city and regional planning.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4950 - Sociology of Music

Credits: 4

The Sociology of Music is a specialized field within Sociology, exploring the social aspects of music. Music surrounds us in society, enhancing our entertainment and serving as the soundtrack of our lives. However, music varies widely across the time and space of human experience. This class investigates global music cultures, and satisfies the cross-cultural component for Sociology majors. We will explore the social production of music and the roles of composers, musicians, and listeners from the classical era to the contemporary age. Emphasis will be placed on how social actors endow music with meaning, and how people use music to construct identities. Music's relationship to social control will also be investigated. Readings assigned for the course are often highly theoretical. A final research paper is required.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, SY 4530

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 4999 - Issues in Sociology

Credits: 4

Gives students the opportunity to examine in greater depth the analysis and discussion of current specialized sociological work in the particular area defined by the instructor (as indicated in the schedule of classes). Students are permitted to take SY 4999 Issues in Sociology for credit up to two times in which two distinct topics are covered.

Prerequisites

SY 1500

, EMS

When Offered:

Depending on faculty availability.

SY 5990 - Senior Seminar

Credits: 4

This is the culminating senior-level research and writing experience for sociology and criminology majors. The course requires students to demonstrate the ability to apply sociological concepts and analysis to the study of a particular topic. To this end, each seminar will have a broad range of topics identified by the Instructor. The student will develop a research project within this range, and complete a major research paper.

Prerequisites

Prerequisites for Sociology Majors: Senior Standing, SY 1500

,SY 4520

, SY 4530

, SY 4540

, and SY 4570

with grades of “C-” or better s for Criminology Majors: Senior Standing, SY 1500

, SY 2600

, SY 4520

, SY 4530

, SY 4570

, and CR 4550

with grades of “C-” or better

When Offered:

Every semester.

Contract All Courses |